In the APSA Public Scholarship Program, graduate students in political science produce summaries of new research in the American Political Science Review. This piece, written by Raymundo Lopez, covers the article by Ala' Alrababa'h, William Marble, Salma Mousa and Alexandra A. Siegel, "Can Exposure to Celebrities Reduce Prejudice? The Effect of Mohamed Salah on Islamophobic Behaviors and Attitudes."

Kicking Bias Off the Field: The Science Behind How Mohamed Salah Reduces Islamophobia

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More Than Just a Game



The English Premier League (EPL) is the most watched sports league in the globe, reaching over 600 million homes annually and showcasing some of the most iconic football clubs in history.

Since the start of the 2020 EPL campaign, no one has scored more goals than Mohamed Salah, who has tallied 132 in league competition. His achievements have earned him prestigious honors—including multiple Golden Boots and the FIFA Puskás Award—and has turned the Egyptian striker into a household name well beyond football circles.

In fact, his rising stardom eventually fueled speculation that the striker's Muslim identity might be reducing Islamophobia among Liverpool fans. A phenomenon later dubbed the *Salah Effect*. This raises a compelling question—under what conditions should we expect this effect to occur?

Enter Alrababa'h, Marble, Mousa, and Siegel—the first scholars to systematically measure and quantify the *Salah Effect*. To test their hypothesis, the authors explore 3 research designs in their APSR article: observational hate crime data, a social media study and an original survey experiment.

Before diving into the findings, it's important to note that the authors ground their framework in the Parasocial Contact Hypothesis (PCT). In short, PCT suggests that positive exposure to marginalized or outgroup members through mass media can reduce prejudice and even foster more favorable attitudes toward them.

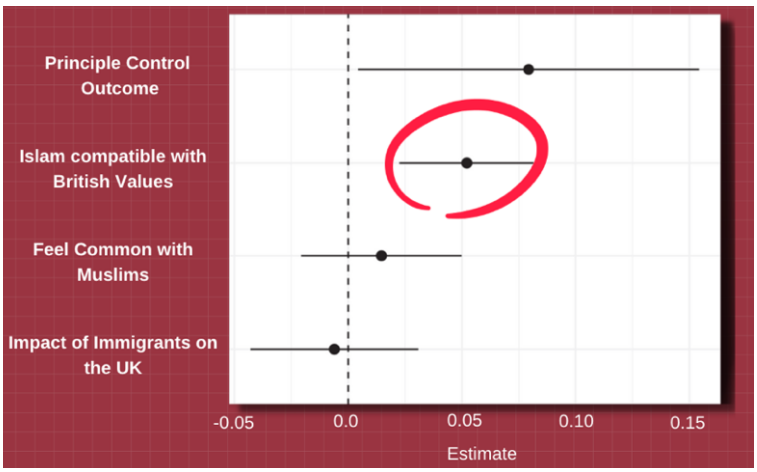
Defending Against Hate

The first analysis examines 936 monthly hate crime observations across England between 2015 and 2018 using the synthetic control method (SCM). The key comparison is Merseyside—the police jurisdiction home to Liverpool F.C.—before and after Salah joined the team. The logic behind the SCM is that it allows the authors to estimate what hate crime levels would have looked

like had earlier trends continued. Their results show a significant drop, a 16% reduction in hate crimes in Merseyside since Mo's arrival.

Next, they analyze 15 million tweets from fans of 6 EPL teams: Arsenal, Chelsea, Everton, Liverpool, Manchester City and Manchester United. To identify Muslim-related content, they use word2vec, a natural language-processing technique that maps words into vectors to capture meaning and context. Ultimately, their analysis shows a 47.8% drop in anti-Muslim tweets among Liverpool fans.

Changing Hearts Beyond the Pitch



Finally, the authors ran a large survey experiment using Facebook Ads (N=8,666) to test whether Salah's visibility shifted attitudes among supporters.

Participants in the treatment group were shown an image of Salah in prayer and a description of his religious beliefs, while the control group saw information about Salah as a player without mention of his religious identity. Respondents who were reminded of Salah's religious practices were about 5 percentage points more likely to say that Islam is compatible with British values.[1]

Taken together, the hate crime analysis, the Twitter data, and the survey experiment offer compelling evidence for what many have called the *Salah Effect*. Their study suggests that high-profile media figures, like Mohamed Salah, can meaningfully shape public attitudes toward marginalized groups. In doing so, the study not only supports the assumptions of the parasocial contact hypothesis but also shows the powerful role representation can play in reducing Islamophobia on one of the world's biggest stages.

If you'd like to see a video version of this summary, click here.

- ALRABABA'H A, MARBLE W, MOUSA S, SIEGEL AA. "Can Exposure to Celebrities Reduce Prejudice? The Effect of Mohamed Salah on Islamophobic Behaviors and Attitudes." *American Political Science Review*. 2021;115(4):1111-1128.

- Word Count: 534

[1] Data from Alrababa'h et al., 2023